The highlight of the morning was a light-hearted fifteen-minute game of football on the outfield. I'm not that great, but at least I don't have Ben Stokes's delusions of grandeur; he thinks he's David de Gea when he'd struggle to get a game in goal for the Dog 'n' Duck. I know people worry about unnecessary injury, but it takes my mind off what's to come.

Some openers secretly relish losing the toss and fielding, since it postpones the pressure, but I was keen to get on with it. I have a set routine: change into whites, insert box, put on right thigh guard, and then inner thigh guard. The process ends with me strapping on my right pad, and then my left. I like the same sense of order at the crease, where I scar the ground by dragging my studs on the line of my guard after every delivery.

You are taught as an eleven-year-old to give yourself sufficient time to adjust to the light before you bat. I did so by rehearsing my stance, and playing the occasional imaginary shot on the glass-fronted balcony. It felt like I was an attraction in a human zoo; I couldn't help but notice the cameras and phones being trained in my direction from a scrum of spectators at the bottom of the Bedser Stand.

I didn't have a tear in my eye as I walked on to the outfield, in deference to the legend of Don Bradman's final Test, at the Oval, when a 0 took his average below 100. I was too busy concentrating on not tripping up, because spikes are tricky on those stairs. The noise surprised me, and grew in intensity as I strode, self-consciously, through the guard of honour.

I entered the game at seventeen, determined to carve my name on it, though playing for England was an Everest-like image, peeking through the clouds in the distance. Yet there I was, shaking the hand of Virat Kohli, Indian captain and national hero, and feeling real warmth and a rare sense of affinity from a capacity crowd. Nervous? Of course. The only antidote was an immersion in familiar virtues.

I'm not big on slogans, but over the years, I determined to be the best version of me that I could be. No gimmicks, no fashion statements, no borrowed habits. I took my usual guard, two, or middle and leg. Then a reminder of the basics: one of the tricks to opening the batting for England is to play the next ball as if the last one never happened.

Watch. The. Ball.

No one really enjoys an innings, especially in the early stages, because it is so fraught with danger. This was double jeopardy, because failure, on this first morning, wasn't purely personal. It would have disappointed so many